

Vietnam Travel Plan: 12-Day and 15-Day Itineraries, Cafés, Shopping & Tailoring, and Practical Tips

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1) Overview

This travel plan provides two well-structured Vietnam itineraries (12 and 15 days) covering major destinations and highlights, plus curated café recommendations, shopping ideas with tailoring advice in Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City, and practical tips (hours, tickets, transport, etiquette). Opening hours and prices are indicative; always re-check locally or with operators.

2) 12-Day Vietnam Itinerary (North → Central → South)

Overview route

- Hanoi (3 days incl. Ninh Binh day trip)
- Ha Long Bay (1 day or overnight cruise option)
- Hue (2 days)
- Hoi An/Da Nang (3 days)
- Ho Chi Minh City (HCMC) + Cu Chi + Mekong Delta (≈2.5–3 days total: arrival evening + 2 full days)

Important notes on hours and tickets

- Opening hours vary seasonally and by management; verify a day in advance on official pages or at ticket offices.
- Ticket prices below are typical recent ranges for planning; confirm on site or via official sources.

Day-by-day

Day 1: Arrive Hanoi – Old Quarter orientation

- Highlights: Hoan Kiem Lake, Ngoc Son Temple, Old Quarter, St. Joseph's Cathedral.
- Must-do: Water puppet show; street food (bun cha, pho, egg coffee).
- Cafés: Café Giang; The Note Coffee; Cong Caphe.
- Tips: Temples ~08:00–17:00; water puppet ~VND 100–200k.

Day 2: Hanoi heritage & museums

- Highlights: Temple of Literature; Hoa Lo Prison; Women's Museum or Ethnology; Train Street (view from permitted cafés).
- Must-do: Early lakeside stroll; ca phe sua da; Dong Xuan Market.
- Cafés: Tranquil Books & Coffee; The Hanoi Social Club; Loading T.

- Tips: Museums may close Mondays; Temple of Literature ~08:00–17:00.

Day 3: Ninh Binh day trip (Trang An/Tam Coc, Mua Cave)

- Highlights: Rowboat (Trang An or Tam Coc); Bich Dong; Mua Cave; Hoa Lu.
- Must-do: 2–3h boat; Mua Cave climb.
- Cafés: Chookie's Hideaway; 24/7 Café & Restaurant.
- Tips & prices: Trang An ~VND 250–300k; Tam Coc ~VND 150–200k.

Day 4: Ha Long Bay – day cruise (or overnight)

- Highlights: Karst islands; caves; kayaking; Titop Island.
- Must-do: Kayak; seafood lunch.
- Cafés: Quayside cafés.
- Tips & transfers: Hanoi ↔ Ha Long ~2.5–3.5h each way.

Day 5: Fly to Hue – Imperial City

- Highlights: Citadel; museum; Perfume River.
- Must-do: Sunset by river; bun bo Hue.
- Cafés: DMZ Café; The One Coffee & Bakery; Sweet Kingdom.
- Tips & prices: Citadel single ~VND 200k; combo ~VND 530–580k.

Day 6: Hue royal tombs & pagodas

- Highlights: Minh Mang, Khai Dinh, Tu Duc; Thien Mu.
- Must-do: Cyclo ride; royal cuisine.
- Tips: Modest dress; combo ticket covers multiple sites.

Day 7: Hue → Hoi An via Hai Van Pass & Marble Mountains

- Highlights: Hai Van views; Lang Co; Marble Mountains.
- Must-do: Scenic transfer.
- Cafés (Da Nang): Wonderlust; 43 Factory Roaster.
- Tips: ~3–4h with stops.

Day 8: Hoi An Ancient Town

- Highlights: Japanese Bridge; Tan Ky Old House; Assembly Halls.
- Must-do: Lantern workshop; Cao Lau.
- Cafés: Reaching Out Tea House; Hoi An Roastery; Pure Coffee.
- Tips & prices: Ancient Town ticket ~VND 120–150k.

Day 9: Hoi An countryside & beaches

- Highlights: Tra Que; Coconut Forest; An Bang Beach.
- Must-do: Bicycle; basket boat; cooking class.
- Cafés: Sound of Silence; Bep 19.
- Tips: Start early; class ~3–4h.

Day 10: My Son Sanctuary → fly to HCMC

- Highlights: Cham ruins.
- Must-do: Morning visit.
- Cafés: HCMC: The Workshop; Shin Coffee.
- Tips & transfers: DAD → SGN ~1h30; city transfer ~30–60 min.

Day 11: HCMC highlights + Cu Chi

- Highlights: Notre-Dame (exterior), Post Office, Book Street, War Remnants; Cu Chi.
- Must-do: Cu Chi half-day; rooftop sunset.
- Cafés: The Workshop; Shin; L'Usine.
- Tips: War Remnants ~07:30–17:30; Cu Chi ~07:00–17:00.

Day 12: Mekong Delta day trip (My Tho/Ben Tre) & departure

- Highlights: Canal boat; coconut candy workshop; orchards; Vinh Trang Pagoda.
- Must-do: Sampan; fruit tasting; local lunch.
- Cafés: Okkio; The Running Bean.
- Tips: 1.5–2h drive each way.

3) 15-Day Vietnam Itinerary (Expanded: Sapa + Overnight Ha Long)

Overview route

- Hanoi (3 days incl. Ninh Binh)
- Sapa (2 days)
- Ha Long Bay (2 days overnight)
- Hue (2 days)
- Hoi An/Da Nang (3 days)
- HCMC + Cu Chi + Mekong (3 days)

General notes

- Opening hours vary; re-check locally.
- Ticket ranges are indicative.

Day-by-day highlights

Days 1–3: Hanoi + Ninh Binh (as above).

Day 4: Hanoi → Sapa (bus ~5–6h or train via Lao Cai)

- Highlights: Sapa square, lake, stone church.
- Cafés: The Hill Station; Le Gecko.

Day 5: Sapa trekking (Cat Cat, Lao Chai, Ta Van)

- Must-do: Guided trek 8–15 km; village visits.
- Tips: Weather varies; check forecasts.

Day 6: Fansipan (optional) → Hanoi return

- Tips: Cable car operations weather-dependent.

Day 7: Hanoi → Ha Long (overnight cruise)

- Must-do: Kayaking; sunset on deck; optional squid fishing.

Day 8: Disembark → Hanoi → fly to Hue

- Transfers: Port → Hanoi ~2.5–3.5h; flight ~1h15; Hue airport → city ~30–40 min.
- Note: Some cruises offer direct shuttles to Noi Bai; alternatives HPH/VDO airports.

Days 9–10: Hue Citadel, tombs & pagodas → Hoi An via Hai Van

Days 11–12: Hoi An Old Town, countryside & beaches

Day 13: My Son → fly to HCMC

Day 14: HCMC city highlights + Cu Chi

Day 15: Mekong Delta day trip & departure

4) Notable Cafés by City

Hanoi (8)

- Café Giang (Old Quarter) – Egg coffee. Hours: 07:30–22:00.
- The Note Coffee (Hoan Kiem) – Lake views. Hours: 07:00–22:00.
- Cong Caphe (Hoan Kiem) – Coconut coffee. Hours: 07:00–23:00.
- Tranquil Books & Coffee (Hoan Kiem) – Quiet, pour-overs. Hours: 08:00–22:00.
- The Hanoi Social Club (near Ly Quoc Su) – Artsy brunch. Hours: 08:00–22:00.
- Loading T (Cathedral) – Cinnamon coffee. Hours: 08:00–21:00.
- Blackbird Coffee (Hoan Kiem) – Espresso. Hours: 07:30–21:30.
- Xofa Café (Hoan Kiem) – Late-night. Hours: 08:00–24:00.

Hue (6)

- DMZ Café (Pham Ngu Lao) – Traveler hub. Hours: 08:00–23:00.
- Tan's Coffee (center) – Strong brews. Hours: 07:00–22:00.
- Cong Caphe (Le Loi) – Riverside. Hours: 07:00–23:00.
- The One Coffee & Bakery (Le Loi) – Pastries. Hours: 07:00–22:00.
- Highlands Coffee (Le Loi) – Chain, Wi-Fi. Hours: 07:00–22:00.
- Gecko Coffee (central) – Garden seating. Hours: 08:00–22:00.

Da Nang (6)

- 43 Factory Roaster (An Thuong/My Khe). Hours: 07:00–22:00.
- Wonderlust (Tran Phu). Hours: 07:00–22:00.
- Cong Caphe (Dragon Bridge). Hours: 07:00–23:00.
- The Coffee House (various). Hours: 07:00–22:00.
- Brewman Coffee (near Han Market). Hours: 07:00–22:00.
- Mia Coffee (An Thuong). Hours: 07:00–22:00.

Hoi An (5)

- Reaching Out Tea House (Tran Phu). Hours: 09:00–18:00.
- Hoi An Roastery (multiple). Hours: 07:00–21:00.
- Sound of Silence (An Bang Beach). Hours: 07:00–20:00.
- Pure Coffee (near Japanese Bridge). Hours: 08:00–21:00.

- Espresso Station (Nguyen Thai Hoc). Hours: 08:00–21:00.

HCMC (8)

- The Workshop (D1, Ngo Duc Ke). Hours: 08:00–22:00.
- Shin Coffee (D1/D3). Hours: 07:00–22:00.
- L'Usine (D1, Dong Khoi/Nguyen Hue). Hours: 08:00–22:00.
- Okkio Caffè (D1, Mac Thi Bui). Hours: 08:00–22:00.
- The Running Bean (D1, Hai Ba Trung). Hours: 07:00–22:00.
- The Coffee House (multiple). Hours: 07:00–22:00.
- Khanh Casa (D1, Ly Tu Trong). Hours: 09:00–22:00.
- Saigon Coffee Roastery (D1/D3). Hours: 08:00–22:00.

Notes: Hours indicative; may extend on weekends. Check venue pages day-of.

5) Popular Local Products & Tailoring (Hanoi & HCMC)

Hanoi products

- Silk; lacquerware; Bat Trang ceramics; lotus tea & specialty coffee; green rice (Cốm); paper art.

Hue products

- Me xung; conical hats; ao dai fabric & embroidery; incense & tea.

Da Nang & Hoi An products

- Lanterns; leather sandals/bags; marble & stone crafts; dried seafood & snacks.

HCMC products

- Marou chocolate; coffee &phin filters; cashews & dried fruit; lacquerware & design goods; suiting/leather.

Mekong products

- Coconut candy; honey/pollen; rice paper & crispy rice snacks.

Tailoring – Ho Chi Minh City (HCMC)

- Cao Minh (D1; near Dong Khoi/Ly Tu Trong): Bespoke/MTM suits & shirts. Lead time 48–72h MTM; bespoke 1–2 weeks. Indicative: suits ~USD 300–600+; shirts ~USD 30–60.
- Mon Amie (D1 focus; Nguyen Trai/Nam Ky Khoi Nghia): Suits/blazers/shirts; fast turnaround 24–72h; suits ~USD 200–350; shirts ~USD 25–50.
- Dòng Phố / suit houses (D1–D3 corridor; Hai Ba Trung/Vo Van Tan): MTM suits/shirts; 48–72h typical.

Tailoring – Hanoi

- Chương Tailor (Hoan Kiem/Ba Dinh; near Trang Thi/Hang Bong): Formal menswear; lead time 2–5 days; suits ~USD 300–600+; shirts ~USD 30–60.

- Tan My Design Tailor Studio (61 Hang Gai, Old Quarter): Women's bespoke (ao dai, dresses) + select menswear; lead time 2–4 days.
- Veston houses (Hang Bong/Hang Gai cluster, Old Quarter): Suits/ao dai/shirts; 24–72h; wide price range.
- Contemporary studios (Tay Ho/Hoan Kiem; West Lake/Old Quarter): Modern cuts; 2–4 days.

Buying tips

- Fit & measurements: Expect ≥2 fittings; bring a reference garment.
- Fabric selection: Verify fiber content; ask for lining/bemberg options.
- Construction: Ask half/full canvassing; check stitching.
- Turnaround planning: Schedule first fitting within 12–24h; allow buffer pre-departure.
- Price transparency: Request itemized quotes; clarify alteration/remake terms.
- Payment & fees: Card surcharges 2–3% possible; cash may yield small discounts—confirm beforehand.
- Fabric authenticity caution: Avoid vague “Italian wool” claims; ask for fabric books with mill names/serials; prefer known mills.
- Care & transport: Garment bags/spare buttons; carry-on suits/dresses.
- Authenticity & warranties: Prefer established shops with clear addresses and recent reviews.
- Tax/refund: VAT refunds limited; assume final prices; ask for invoices if needed.

6) Practical Traveler Tips & Logistics

Intercity transport (indicative)

- Flights: HAN↔HUI ~1h15 (USD 40–120); DAD↔SGN ~1h30 (USD 40–130); HAN↔DAD ~1h20 (USD 35–110); HAN↔SGN ~2h10 (USD 50–150). Add 60–90 min for transfers.
- Trains: Hanoi→Hue ~12–14h (USD 30–70); Hue→Da Nang ~2.5–3.5h (USD 8–20); Hanoi↔Lao Cai ~7.5–8.5h (USD 25–50). Book soft sleeper.
- Buses: Hanoi↔Sapa ~5–6h (USD 12–25); Hanoi↔Ha Long ~2.5–3.5h (USD 8–15); Hue↔Hoi An ~3–4h (USD 8–15).
- Private transfers: Hue→Hoi An via Hai Van ~3–5h with stops (USD 60–120/car); Ha Long Port→Noi Bai Airport ~3–3.5h (shared shuttle ~USD 15–25 pp).

Local transport

- Grab ride-hailing; reputable taxis (Mai Linh, Vinasun); cyclos; motorbike rentals ~VND 120k–200k/day; bicycles ~VND 50k–100k/day; walk steadily when crossing.

Airport transfer price ranges (indicative)

- Noi Bai → Hanoi Old Quarter: VND 250k–400k.
- Tan Son Nhat → District 1: VND 100k–200k.
- Da Nang Airport → Hoi An: Private car VND 300k–500k; shared shuttle VND 120k–180k pp.

Ticketing info (key sites)

- Reminder: Some museums/sites close Mondays/holidays (Tet). Re-check hours the day before visiting.
- Hoi An Ancient Town: ~VND 120k–150k; sites ~08:00–17:00.

- Hue Citadel/tombs: Citadel ~VND 200k; combo ~VND 530k–580k; ~07:00–17:00.
- Trang An/Tam Coc: Trang An ~VND 250k–300k; Tam Coc ~VND 150k–200k; boats 2–3h; first boats ~07:00–08:00.
- Ha Long: Day cruise 4–6h; Hanoi↔Ha Long ~2.5–3.5h; some cruises offer direct port→Noi Bai shuttles; alternatives HPH/VDO.
- Water Puppet (Hanoi): ~VND 100k–200k; multiple shows.
- My Son: Opens ~06:00; last entry mid-late afternoon.
- Marble Mountains (Da Nang): ~07:00–17:30.
- War Remnants (HCMC): ~07:30–17:30.
- Cu Chi Tunnels: ~07:00–17:00.

Etiquette & cultural notes

- Modest dress in temples; remove shoes when posted; ask before photos; “xin chào” greeting; tipping optional but appreciated (guides/drivers ~VND 50k–150k pp).

Money, payments, connectivity

- Cash common; cards at hotels/malls/restaurants. ATMs widespread; check fees. Exchange at banks/counters. Card surcharges 2–3% possible.
- Budget examples: Meal VND 50k–120k; coffee VND 25k–80k; taxi VND 40k–100k.
- SIM/eSIM: Viettel/Vinaphone/Mobifone; passport for SIM; eSIM available. Wi-Fi widespread; carry offline maps.

Health, safety, seasons

- Traffic: Cross steadily; eye contact. Scams: prefer metered taxis/ride-hailing; avoid unofficial sellers.
- Water/food: Bottled/filtered; choose busy stalls.
- Sun/heat: Hydrate; sunscreen/hat/repellent.
- Rain/typhoons: Central coast Aug–Oct; Ha Long/Ninh Binh winter mist; Sapa fog/rain—check before Fansipan/treks.
- Medical: Pharmacies common; travel insurance recommended; know nearest international clinic.

Booking & planning

- High season: Book flights/cruises/tours early (Tet/holidays/summer). Small-group tours for Ha Long/Mekong/Cu Chi/My Son; read reviews. Build 1–2h buffers around airport transfers/cruise disembarkations. Check visa requirements; passport needed for SIM/hotels.